



up to 50 per cent of the passengers added during the pandemic. Tekriwal also attributes this rise to shrinking business class seats in a market dominated by low-cost carriers. “The absence of business class seats on regular commercial flights may have also led to passengers mindful of their privacy to charter aircraft,” she says.

The UDAN-Regional Connectivity Scheme, which was launched in 2017 to connect remote areas, is also benefitting charter operations as regional airports have improved substantially, allowing charter flights to travel to the country’s interiors. “Smaller towns of India are throwing up consumers like never before,” says Club One Air’s Mehra.

YOUR FLYING MACHINE

Very soon, you won’t have to be a Tata or an Ambani to own a private jet. Enthused by the growing market for charters, Group Captain Bali is working with BAOA members to offer fractional ownership of private aircraft. This



“Earlier, they [businesspersons] used to travel alone or with an official delegation. But now you often find them traveling with their families on business trips”

Rajan Mehra
CEO, CLUB ONE AIR

will allow multiple owners to not only share the cost of purchasing an aircraft, but also the freedom to use it. Club One had tried to introduce the concept in 2006, but it didn’t take off then due to taxation and regulatory hurdles. But things are different now. “Fractional ownership is going to give a huge boost to business aviation as it will allow people outside of India Inc. to consider owning an aircraft,” says Bali.

As per aviation regulator DGCA, the 95 non-scheduled operator permit holders in India had a fleet of 330 charter aircraft as of April 2022. With consolidation happening, Group Captain Bali predicts “the number of operators may come down further”. However, “the number of private aircraft is bound to increase”.

“It was okay to travel by a Rolls-Royce or be seen with a \$100,000 Birkin bag, but it was not okay to travel by a private jet. But that perception is slowly changing,” is how Tekriwal sums up the situation. **BT**

@manishpant22